

Rwenzori AgriLED Initiative

News Letter March 2026 Issue 1



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What is AgriLED?

The Rwenzori AgriLED Initiative, was approved by Cabinet, is a flagship program under Uganda's decentralized poverty alleviation framework. It targeted Rwenzori region districts of Kasese, Bundibugyo, Bunyangabu, Ntoroko, Kabarole, Kyenjojo, and Kyegegwa with

a UGX 649 billion investment over three years. It was vision to transform local governments into engines of wealth creation, eradicate poverty, and attract private investment through agro-industrialization.

Key Impacts

1. Infrastructure Development:



Farm-to-market roads reduced transport costs and improved buyer access and Kyenjojo, Kabarole and Kasese planned land acquisition for an industrial park and improvement of four major markets.

Case story 1:

"AgriLED has given us market, milk coolers, tractors, coffee factories and roads that connect our farms to markets. Before, we struggled to sell our produce, but now buyers can reach us easily." — Grace, Kyenjojo.

2. Agro-Industrialization:



Agro-processing facilities established for crops and livestock, Expansion of cross-border trade opportunities with the DRC and Increased production through seedling and livestock distribution.

Case Story 2:

Cage Fish Project in Kabarole Over 900 households benefited from 30 fish cages distributed across crater lakes. Farmers reported higher incomes from improved fish breeds, while youth gained employment. Communities requested expansion to reach more associations.

3. Industrial Parks – Hope for Toro

Case Story 3:

Kabarole AgriLED Industrial Park The 502-acre Kyembogo site was envisioned as a hybrid hub for agro-processing, innovation, and sustainable industry. Despite delays, it remains a beacon of hope. Communities in Kyenjojo petitioned government to degazette part of Matiiri Forest Reserve for an industrial park, even including the demand in a memo to the President during the 2026 elections. Kyegegwa also voiced strong calls for industrialization.

Collective voice:

Industrialization is not a luxury but a necessity. AgriLED parks symbolize dignity, jobs, and prosperity.

4. Employment Creation:

Agro-industries and improved market access generated jobs, especially for youth and women.

Case story 4:

"Through OWC-AgriLED, we built a coffee factory in Katooke and Kihura Sub County, Mukunyu Market among otherskj. This allowed us to add value to our coffee, create jobs, and drive poverty out of our homes." — Julius Twongyirwe.

5. Local Government Empowerment:



Strengthened district revenue bases through enterprise growth and enhanced planning and coordination capacity at district and parish levels.

Case Story 5:

Bunyangabu & Kabarole Equipment Handover In June 2022, districts received UGX 6.3 billion worth of equipment—tractors, milk coolers, rice haulers, and maize mills. Minister Frank Tumwebaze emphasized improved food security and market opportunities. Farmers saw the tools as gateways to transformation, though leaders urged recruitment of more extension workers to maximize impact.



6. Poverty Reduction Potential:

Direct household benefits through improved incomes, market access, employment and alignment with NDP III and NDP IV goals of agro-industrialization and inclusive growth.

Case Story 6:

Farmers Receive UGX 49 billion Infrastructure NAADS procured tractors, milk coolers, maize mills, coffee hullers, grain stores, and irrigation schemes across Rwenzori districts. These investments improved storage, processing, and marketing capacity, laying the foundation for sustainable poverty reduction.

Comparative Insights: PDM vs. AgriLED in Kyenjojo District

Pillar	PDM (Parish Development Model)	AgriLED (Agro-Industrialization for Local Economic Development)	Analysis
Agricultural Value Chain	Training & loans; weak storage/processing.	Agro-processing facilities, value addition.	AgriLED stronger in linking production to markets.
Infrastructure & Services	No dedicated funding; transport challenges.	Built farm-to-market roads, reduced costs.	AgriLED excels; PDM lags.
Financial Inclusion	Strongest pillar: 167 SACCOs, UGX 34B disbursed.	Limited direct transfers; focus on enterprise growth.	PDM strong in finance; AgriLED complements with infrastructure.
Social Services	Minimal investment; health/education gaps.	Indirect benefits via infrastructure.	Both weak; needs integration.
Mindset Change	Sensitization but over-expectation persists.	Promotes commercial farming & enterprise.	AgriLED more enterprise-driven.
Data Systems (PDMIS)	Beneficiary registration but unreliable system.	Relies on district planning & OWC structures.	PDM needs stronger digital accountability.
Governance	Parish chiefs recruited; underfunded admin.	District councils empowered; stronger role.	AgriLED strengthens local government empowerment.

Key Insight:

PDM is strong in financial inclusion but weak in infrastructure and value chains., AgriLED excels in infrastructure, agro-processing, and market access. Scaling AgriLED alongside PDM ensures balanced development. And ensure OWC coordinators participate fully in PDM and AgriLED initiatives.

Challenges & Gaps

- Some AgriLED projects remain incomplete.
- Need for inclusivity (women, youth, marginalized groups).
- Weak accountability mechanisms for fund utilization.
- Understaffing of extension workers.
- Over-reliance on financial inclusion under PDM.
- Off hand of OWC coordinators on AgriLED projects affected implementation

Policy Recommendations

1. Institutionalize Accountability: Transparent monitoring of fund flows and utilization.
2. Balance PDM Pillars: Strengthen production, infrastructure, market access, mindset change, governance, and service delivery.
3. Scale Successes: Expand AgriLED's road infrastructure model, OWC's value addition approach and ensure OWC coordinators are fully involved in implementation of AgriLED and complete the already started AgriLED projects.
4. Community Engagement: Integrate grassroots voices into program design and evaluation.
5. Public-Private Partnerships: Leverage private sector investment for sustainability.

Conclusion:

The Rwenzori AgriLED Initiative demonstrates how infrastructure, agro-industrialization, and financial inclusion can transform livelihoods. Success stories from fish farming in Kabarole, to equipment handovers in Bunyangabu and market places in Mukunyu Kyenjojo to the enduring hope for industrial parks in Toro show that communities are ready for transformation. For the people of Rwenzori, AgriLED is not just policy it is action, hope, and the promise of prosperity.

Acknowledgement:

We acknowledge support for AgriLED by GoU (Government of Uganda) and Partners.

This impact brief has been made possible by: Chris Kaijuka , W.Byaruhanga , James Nkojo and Rev.Atuhairu Moses.

Credit. National Strategic Cluster-Rwenzori Region @2026

